TSA 2019

Critical Thinking

Questions taken from the TSA Oxford 2019 Section 1 question paper

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Questions are numbered 1 to 25 for this set. The number in brackets shows the question's number in the original TSA 2019 paper, e.g. **1 (Q3)**.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to the 25 questions in this set: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes).

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (Q1) Like other booming cities, including New York, London has thrived amid globalisation. It is growing by 100 000 new residents a year. However, if London has given striving people plenty of reasons to come, it has done a poor job of housing them. The median price of a London home has tripled over the past two decades. Since 2001 the disposable income of people renting property has fallen by 30 per cent as a result. Businesses are worried too. Commercial property in central London is twice as expensive as in New York. Productivity has begun to slow as promising firms are forced out. Overpriced property is costing London the economic and human diversity on which its prosperity depends.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A London needs striving people in order to prosper.

B Londoners in rented homes have 30 per cent less to spend.

C London has done a poor job of housing its new residents.

D Businesses are worried by the recent slowdown in productivity.

E Expensive property is costing London the diversity it needs to prosper.

2 (Q3) A high degree of self-discipline is one quality exhibited by all athletes who have reached the uppermost levels of competition, whatever the sport. This amount of self-discipline is in evidence long after the initial excitement of a sport has worn off, and an athlete has had to keep going through years of painful and repetitive training sessions. The example of top athletes suggests one approach to improving student behaviour and educational achievement. If more young people could begin training programmes akin to those of elite athletes, they too would develop exceptional levels of personal discipline to apply within their studies.

Which one of the following best expresses the flaw in the above argument?

A High levels of self-discipline may not be all that it takes to become an elite athlete.

B Young people may be able to develop self-discipline through other kinds of activities.

C The kind of coaching support available to elite athletes may not be accessible to the general population.

D Good behaviour and educational achievement during one's school years may not be essential for going on to lead a successful life.

E Strong self-discipline may not be an effect of the training but rather a capacity already possessed by athletes as they start their training.

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3 (Q4) Young people are becoming ever more responsible. They are less likely to take drugs or drink than past generations. Very few have serious problems with alcohol or drugs. It is people in their forties who are most likely to be admitted to hospital for drinking-related problems. The latest figures on drug addiction show that 39% of heroin addicts are now over the age of forty, up from 19% in 2006. Fewer than ever are under the age of twenty-four. The number of young adults in prison is falling, but our overcrowded prisons are increasingly home to the older generation: between 2002 and 2013, the number of middle-aged men locked up increased by 130%. The same is true of suicide rates: on both sides of the Atlantic fewer young people but more middle-aged men are killing themselves.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A Young people have far fewer health problems than older generations.

B Some social problems are increasingly problems of middle-aged people.

C People who drink are more likely to engage in criminal activity.

D Drink, drugs and suicide are the biggest killers of middle-aged people.

E Young people are likely to develop harmful behaviours later in life.

4 (Q5) Adults thinking back on their experience of school almost always remember with most gratitude the teachers who taught them more than just a subject, and prepared them for life, not just for an exam. But the current generation of students may not have the same experiences to look back on in future years because the role of teachers has changed. The focus for both students and teachers is now mainly on exam results, and that is how their success or failure is measured. For teachers to share their lives with their students, offering them a model of adulthood to which to aspire, is therefore no longer considered desirable. So children today receive a less valuable education than their parents and grandparents did.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Education for life is of greater value than merely passing exams.

B Adults looking back on their childhood often remember only the good parts.

C Many young people have higher ambitions than becoming like their teachers.

D Exam results are the vital keys which open the door to education and a livelihood.

E Offering students a model of adulthood is a more satisfying role than helping them to pass exams.

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5 (Q9) Texting is the preferred method of communication among young people, with 72% of teenagers saying they text regularly and one in three sending more than a hundred texts per day. Unfortunately, however, very few youngsters seem able to communicate using grammatically correct sentences. They seem to think it 'gr8' that correct spelling is no longer considered necessary. Many local employers have complained that school-leavers have no idea how to communicate appropriately, whether face-to-face or in business letters. Many written job applications are phrased so poorly that they go straight in the bin. Mobile phones were banned in my daughter's school last year, a move which has proved fully justified. Since then test scores in English have improved. All schools need to introduce a similar ban.

Which one of the following best expresses the flaw in the above argument?

A It makes a false statistical comparison between the 72% of teenagers who merely text regularly and those who send more than a hundred texts in a day.

B It assumes that, because test scores improved after the ban on mobile phones, the improvement was due to the ban.

C The argument rests on the assumption that communicating by text is inappropriate.

D Its conclusion, that communicating by text is inappropriate, merely restates one of the reasons given in support of the argument.

E It assumes that correct spelling is a necessary requirement for gaining employment.

6 (Q10) While it is a woman, Ada Lovelace, who is often credited with originating the concept of software, today's computer tech-related jobs are held mostly by men. The tech sector must continue to work against factors that inhibit gender equality within it. One such factor appears to be prejudice about women's abilities to write computer programming code. A recent study of a program-sharing and development website analysed the rates by which suggested code changes were accepted by website users according to the gender of the user contributing the changes. In cases where the contributor's gender was not made clear on the website, 72 per cent of the suggestions made by women were accepted. In cases where the contributor's gender was revealed to be female, the acceptance rate fell to 63 per cent.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Over the time period the website was studied, more female users than male users rejected suggested code changes overall.

B Leading firms in the tech sector have undertaken a variety of high-profile initiatives to encourage more women to pursue computer programming careers.

C No meaningful differences existed between the code changes suggested by female users who revealed their gender on the website and those who did not.

D Even by modern standards, Ada Lovelace received an extensive education in mathematics and the sciences.

E Male contributors to the website experienced a similar drop in their code change acceptance rates when their gender was revealed.

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7 (Q11) Schools have a duty to support the well-being of their students, and sport is one way to enhance this. Although many young people don't enjoy the competitive side of sport, there are many physical activities that don't require a competitive element, such as hillwalking and caving. Schools should offer these, or other non-competitive physical activities, as an alternative to traditional games lessons. Many people don't continue to play sport after they leave school, yet physical fitness is important in maintaining general health and the ability to work. Introducing alternative physical activities that are attractive for less competitive adults is therefore an important part of preparing students for life after school.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Schools have a duty to prepare students for life after school.

B Many young people don't enjoy the competitive side of sport.

C Many people don't continue to play sport after they leave school.

D Schools should offer non-competitive alternatives to traditional games lessons.

E Young people should be encouraged to find a sport they enjoy.

8 (Q15) Recently a pioneering natural flood management scheme slowed river peak flow by 15 to 20 per cent, saving a small town's museum and several homes. As part of this scheme, special dams, designed to leak water gradually, were installed in nearby hills to slow the flow of water off the slopes. An upstream flood storage reservoir was installed, along with the planting of thousands of trees and the restoration of heather moorland, which acted as a sponge. Around half of the reduction in flood water in the town was due to the upstream land management measures, and half due to the effect of the flood storage area. Natural flood management measures improve water quality, prevent erosion and, in some cases, store carbon.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A The reduction in peak flow of a river would be insufficient to prevent flooding if there was very heavy rainfall.

B The benefits of natural flood management schemes go beyond reducing flood risk.

C All natural flood management methods are equally effective in reducing river flow.

D Natural flood management should be introduced in all areas at risk of flooding.

E Natural flood management methods are most effective in hilly upland areas.

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9 (Q16) The government is planning an increase in fuel tax later this year as part of its strategy to meet carbon emissions targets. Yet motorists and road transport companies have suffered crippling price rises of up to 30% in petrol and diesel bills in the past year because of fuel taxes. The government has enjoyed a £505 million windfall from high oil prices in the last six months alone, with extra revenue coming from North Sea oil reserves. A further increase in fuel tax will impact on all UK households because it will eventually push up the price of shop goods and inflation. So the government must abandon its planned tax increase.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above passage?

A The impact on people's pockets is more important than the need to control carbon emissions.

B The cost of fuel is too high and must be reduced.

C The only justification for higher fuel taxes is to reduce carbon emissions.

D Road transport companies could go out of business if fuel tax is increased.

E The government could use its increased levels of North Sea oil revenue to reduce fuel taxes.

10 (Q17) Despite the recent decline in numbers of people getting married, it appears that there is still much to recommend it. Married people are happier, wealthier and live longer. Husbands and wives have a lower risk of disease and a higher life expectancy. They smoke less, drink less and eat more healthily. Those who get married and stay married have on average double the amount of wealth of those who never marry. Surveys show that they are happier than single people and less likely to experience mid-life depression. Married couples benefit from stronger networks of support, with relatives providing more care and assistance in old age and in times of need. Finding and committing to a marriage partner is a goal well worth pursuing.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above reasoning?

A Research suggests that being married boosts the chances of surviving cancer.

B Statistics on marriage do not differentiate between those who have children and those who do not.

C In many countries, being married gives advantages in terms of tax payments.

D Individuals in conflict-ridden relationships are more prone to illness than happy couples.

E Wealthier couples are four times more likely to marry than poorer couples.

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11 (Q21) It is universally recognised that Africa's conservation tourism provides employment, generates wealth and educates future generations while saving endangered species. So we should champion tourism for the sake of conservation. Tourism in the Arctic is thus to be welcomed. As the Arctic ice melts, new shipping routes are opening up. It is unfair to characterise the presence of a large cruise ship in the Northwest Passage as 'extinction tourism' that merely indulges people who want to view endangered animals before it is too late. The tourists will return home better informed about the Arctic's fragile ecosystem.

Which one of the following best expresses the flaw in the above argument?

A It argues a general rule on the basis of one successful example of wildlife tourism.

B It assumes that wildlife tourists only want to see endangered animals.

C It assumes that wildlife tourism is more important than successful conservation.

D It assumes that the cruise-ship tourists will see enough to return home committed to the conservation of the Arctic ecosystem.

E The argument implies that conservation tourism will inevitably lead to the extinction of some species of animal.

12 (Q22) If the vice president did act unlawfully in this matter, he would definitely have had to resign. Since we have confirmation that he has resigned, he must have broken the law.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A If the snake that bit this woman was a king cobra, then she would be dead by now. As she is alive and well, the snake can't have been a king cobra.

B If the snake had yellow markings, then it was a pit viper. You say it did have yellow markings, so it must have been a pit viper.

C If what Mahmood saw was a diamondback rattlesnake, he would have been in real danger. Since there are no rattlesnakes where Mahmood was, he was actually quite safe.

D If a snake bite goes untreated for too long, there can be serious complications. Since I got prompt treatment, I didn't have any complications.

E If the snake that bit this victim was venomous, then the wound would be very inflamed. We can see that there is severe inflammation, so the snake must have been venomous.

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13 (Q23) It's common for people to agree in principle to socially useful projects such as the opening of centres for people with serious mental health problems. However, if the project is planned for the area where they live, they tend to object and suggest that alternative locations would be preferable. While they approve of the general idea of such projects, they won't tolerate any negative effects on their own lives. We really don't want to go back to outdated practices of housing people with mental health problems in remote areas with no contact with the general population. So we have to accept that these projects can only work if we live near, and interact with, the people they are designed to help. Practise what you preach!

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A People who think sport has been tainted by bribery and performance-enhancing drugs should not buy tickets to sporting events.

B People who think more money should be spent on the health service should not complain when their income tax is increased to fund it.

C Parents who think too much 'screen time' is bad for young children should not buy them so many electronic gadgets.

D People who choose to be vegetarians should seek to persuade others not to eat meat or fish.

E People who have benefitted from grants or bursaries for university education should lobby for others to have the same advantages.

14 (Q27) People are quick to connect attempts to reduce the effects of climate change with the protection of the environment. However, responding to climate change is much more important for humanity than for nature. In the history of the planet, the relative stability of temperatures in the last ten thousand years is the exception rather than the norm. Nature has always found a way to adapt to large temperature variations but human civilisations, all of which have evolved in the last ten thousand years, have developed in a period with unusually reliable and predictable weather. Nature will find a way to move on, but climate change is potentially devastating for humans.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A People are quick to connect climate change policies with environmental protection.

B Acting against climate change is more important for humans than for the environment.

C Nature has always found a way to adapt to large temperature variations.

D Human civilisations have not yet been exposed to really large variations in temperature.

E Nature will find a way to adapt, but climate change is potentially devastating for humans.

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15 (Q28) Chiropractors rely heavily on manipulating their patients' spines. This has benefits for some patients, but more than half of all patients suffer mild to moderate adverse effects after seeing a chiropractor. These are mostly local and referred pains that usually last for two to three days. Chiropractors often claim that these are necessary steps on the road to getting better. However, several hundred cases have been documented in which patients were seriously and often permanently damaged after chiropractic manipulations. What usually happens in these tragic instances is that, upon manipulation of the upper spine, an artery supplying the brain is overstretched and simply breaks up, leading to a stroke that can prove fatal.

Which one of the following is a conclusion that can be drawn from the above passage?

A Chiropractic therapy should be banned.

B Chiropractic therapy may do more harm than good.

C The spine is the most delicate part of the human body.

D People should see a doctor before going to a chiropractor.

E Pain is a necessary part of the healing process.

16 (Q29) Drivers found to be committing offences such as speeding are now offered the choice between paying the police for a re-education course or taking the traditional penalty of paying a fine and receiving penalty points on their licence. It is no surprise that the number of motorists opting for re-education courses has tripled in five years, but the high cost of such courses has led to accusations that police forces might use the new system for their own benefit. They could easily set up speed traps, catch a number of motorists slightly over the limit, and generate easy income for themselves. Re-education courses are a good idea in theory, but open to abuse by cash-starved police forces.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A The cost of running re-education courses is less than the combined contributions of participants.

B Re-education is more effective than punishment in preventing further motoring offences.

C Police forces are more interested in generating income than in preventing motoring offences.

D The number of driving offences committed in the last five years has tripled.

E Fear of losing a driving licence is greater than fear of financial hardship.

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17 (Q33) A band of rebellious traders in Wales has decided to take their whole town 'offshore' in protest at the insignificant amounts of UK tax paid by big businesses. An alliance of shopkeepers from the town want to use the same controversial loopholes favoured by huge multinationals such as Google so that they too can legally avoid UK tax. The coffee giant Starbucks, for example, has been branded immoral for transferring revenues out of the UK and into the Netherlands and Switzerland, where they receive sweetened tax deals. But the shopkeepers of the town cannot have it both ways. If they believe it is immoral for Starbucks to avoid UK tax, it is immoral for them, too. They should continue to pay UK tax in full.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A The sole purpose of the protest is to pressure the government into tackling tax avoidance by big business.

B If the shopkeepers are successful, every town could follow their lead, harming the UK economy even further.

C Small businesses acting alone cannot obtain the same tax breaks as the giant corporations.

D Every time the government comes up with a way of tackling tax avoidance, lawyers simply find a new loophole.

E One of the town traders found that last year he paid seven times more corporation tax than Facebook.

18 (Q34) Much concern is paid to the hazards posed by people using mobile phones while operating motor vehicles. Although using a smartphone or other mobile phone behind the wheel of a car is most certainly dangerous, research is showing that very frequent usage of the phones is harmful more generally. A study has found that individuals with relatively high levels of mobile phone usage are more likely to demonstrate cognitive failures, which can range from forgetting appointments to accidentally bumping into things in the environment. Cognitive failures are associated with the short attention spans also observed in high-frequency mobile phone users. Clearly, if people want to reduce their risk of cognitive failures, they should limit the amount of time they spend on their mobile phones.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A High-frequency mobile phone users may have had short attention spans prior to the formation of their phone usage habits.

B Limiting one's smartphone or mobile phone usage may not be a sufficient strategy for significantly reducing cognitive failures.

C Mobile phones may play an important role in the completion of everyday tasks in the lives of many people.

D Smartphones and other mobile phones may have different applications or features that are not all used in the exact same fashion.

E The risks posed by using a mobile phone while driving may be much greater than those posed by too-frequent usage of the phones overall.

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19 (Q35) Nearly everyone thinks it is a bad thing to be a hypocrite, because it is profoundly dishonest to pretend to have moral standards that you do not actually have. But pretending you are better than you are is evidence that you still accept the moral principles you have failed to follow. So it is better than being shameless about your moral failings. Perceived in this way, hypocrisy can be considered to be a virtue. Being a hypocrite shows you feel a need to hide some aspect of your life because it would be too embarrassing to allow it into the open. Many hypocrites wish they were the people they pretend to be: so perhaps one day they will succeed.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Hypocrisy is evidence of an inner need to conceal a shameful aspect of one's life.

B It is bad not to show any shame for the mistakes one makes in life.

C In some cases, hypocrisy may lead to moral improvement.

D It is possible to think of hypocrisy as a good thing.

E Hypocrisy is a serious moral weakness.

20 (Q39) One of the greatest achievements of English grammar schools was the development and dissemination of a sophisticated system of standard punctuation for the English language. The complex rules for the use of commas conveyed a range of precise meanings, while the choice between semi-colon, colon and full stop expressed the exact, and often subtle, relationship between statements. Without this kind of attention to punctuation, there is bound to be a loss of precision in communication and in thinking. The current use of commas to join statements together, without any regard for grammar or the nature of the link between them, lacks rigour and covers up lazy thinking.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above?

A Most writers do not want to waste time thinking through the exact connections between their ideas.

B Only a minority of people ever grasped the finer aspects of the traditional system of punctuation.

C Schools should go back to teaching the traditional system of punctuation.

D The government should reintroduce grammar schools into the UK.

E The vocabulary and grammar of a language naturally evolve over time, and the same is true of punctuation.

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21 (Q40) Long hours and poor pay have become commonly accepted, but they are taking a heavy toll on life at home. It is not a pretty picture: an economy where high levels of stress and anxiety are normal, where people get ill because they have lost control of their time, and where marriages are damaged and children suffer. Yet it is a situation that politicians invite us to applaud. They praise 'strivers' and 'hard-working people', not chilled-out, caring mums and dads. The longer and harder we work, the more admirable we are supposed to be. So the political slogans have clearly been effective, but the resulting glorification of work has made us miserable.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Most employees are not satisfied with their salary.

B Political slogans significantly affect people's everyday behaviour.

C Restructuring the working week would be beneficial for the economy.

D Companies could afford shorter hours or better pay for their employees.

E People who experience less stress at work are better parents.

22 (Q41) Despite recent improvements to their training, a new study suggests that the police are as susceptible as the general public to holding false beliefs about crime and punishment. Participants in the study were questioned about their views on a number of crime-related myths such as 'capital punishment is an effective way to deter criminal activity' – myths, because they are unsupported by research evidence. Police were just as likely to endorse the misconceptions as the lay participants and, moreover, were more confident in their false beliefs. This is a worrying example of a 'scientist–practitioner gap', a term which describes a situation where professionals do not accept the evidence of research relevant to their roles. Studies have shown that training can permanently reduce the 'scientist–practitioner gap'. Police officers need more training.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A The recruitment process for new police officers often fails to identify false beliefs held by applicants.

B The majority of police officers do not support the return of capital punishment.

C The science–practitioner gap is a common phenomenon in many professions, not just the police.

D Police training has often been criticised in the media for being insufficiently practical.

E Police officers whose views are not evidence-based are more likely to have complaints made against them by members of the public.

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23 (Q45) An accident at the Fukushima nuclear power plant in Japan in 2011 caused the release of radioactive material, resulting in around half a million people being evacuated from the area. These people have not been allowed to return to the area because of the health risks of exposure to radiation. But the psychological consequences of long-term evacuation may be more significant than the physical effects of radiation. People who wish to return to live in the area around Fukushima should be allowed to. Studies of a similar situation at Chernobyl showed that average life expectancy for evacuees reduced – not predominantly because of cancer caused by radiation, but because of depression, alcoholism and suicide due to the impact of permanent evacuation. There is, moreover, massive disagreement in the scientific community over how much radiation is 'safe'.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A The increased risks of cancer due to exposure to radiation have been exaggerated.

B There is no consensus among scientists about what constitutes a safe level of radiation.

C People who are forcibly evacuated from their homes experience reduced life expectancy.

D People should be allowed to make their own decisions about living in the affected area.

E The negative effects of radiation may be less significant than the psychological consequences of evacuation.

24 (Q46) Your cake will be tasty only if you use fresh ingredients which you can only buy at the market. You did not go to the market, so your cake will not be tasty.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A You can only be happy if you are healthy. To be healthy, you have to eat a lot of vegetables. You eat a lot of vegetables so you must be happy.

B She either went to school or to the playground. She is not in the playground, so she must have gone to school.

C If you light a candle, there is light and, if there is light, I am able to read to you. You must have lit a candle because I can read.

D Listening to loud music through earphones damages hearing. His hearing is fine which means that he must not have listened to loud music through earphones.

E Good knowledge of the car is necessary for fixing it. Without fixing the car, we will not arrive at the wedding in time. We will surely be late as we do not have good knowledge of the car.

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25 (Q47) Costs of health care in the UK are shared through taxation, but some of those who can afford to pay for a higher standard of care choose to do so. Some think it is immoral for rich people to receive better health care simply because they can afford to pay for it. But the whole point of money is to enable those who have it to improve the quality of life of themselves and their families. If money did not offer such advantages, it would not motivate people to develop their skills or to work harder in order to earn more. Since people are morally entitled to use their money to buy advantages for themselves and their loved ones, there can be no objection to private medicine.

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A People who have been born rich should not waste their inherited wealth in gambling, self-indulgence and extravagant living.

B It is a good thing for people from rich countries to take foreign holidays, because the income generated by tourism benefits the local economy.

C People who are born talented are under a moral obligation to develop their talents and to apply them energetically for the good of humanity.

D Rich people should give away some of their wealth to benefit those less fortunate than themselves.

E Inheritance tax should be set at a fairly low rate so that the children of rich parents inherit enough money to make a substantial difference to their lives.

END OF TEST

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